

Assignment 1: Psychology: Myths and Realities

Name: Pavithra Kamath
USN: 25MSDSR026
Class: MSc (DSA)
Subject: Psychology and Life Skills

Reflection on My Beliefs About Psychology

Before I joined this course, I thought psychology was mostly about mind reading, therapy, or just common sense ideas about people. These beliefs came from movies, TV shows, and what I heard from others, which often gave a very simple or even wrong picture of psychology. After learning in class, I now understand that psychology is a science that studies how people think, feel, and behave using research and evidence. This has changed the way I see things I question assumptions more, I know mental illness is often misunderstood, and I realize intelligence can grow in different ways. Psychology now feels like a subject that helps me think critically and treat people with more empathy.

Myths I Believed Before Taking The Course

Myth 1: Psychology is about “mind reading.”

- **Why I believed it:** When I was younger, I often saw TV shows and movies where detectives or therapists seemed to instantly know what someone was thinking. Even my friends would joke that psychologists could “see through you,” so I started to believe that psychology was basically mind reading.
- **What I learned:** Through this course, I realized psychology is not about guessing thoughts at all. It’s a science that studies behaviour and mental processes using research, experiments, and observation. For example, cognitive psychology looks at how memory and attention work by measuring behaviour and brain activity, not by magically reading minds. This helped me understand that psychology is evidence-based and far more structured than I once thought.

Myth 2: Intelligence is fixed and measured only by IQ.

- **Why I believed it:** Back in school, I often heard teachers and classmates talk about IQ scores as if they defined how smart someone was. Media also reinforced this idea by ranking people based on IQ, so I thought intelligence was something permanent that couldn’t change.

- ***What I learned:*** Through this course, I realized intelligence is not just about IQ. It can grow and develop depending on our environment, practice, and experiences. I learned about Gardner's theory of multiple intelligences, which shows that people can be talented in different ways, like music, sports, or social skills. I also learned about emotional intelligence, which highlights the importance of empathy and self-awareness. This helped me understand that intelligence is diverse and flexible, not limited to a single test score.

Myth 3: People with mental illness are always violent.

- ***Why I believed it:*** I used to think this because movies and news stories often focus on extreme cases where someone with a mental illness commits a crime. Seeing those portrayals made me assume that mental illness was directly linked to aggression.
- ***What I learned:*** In class, I came to understand that this belief is not true. Most people with mental illness are not violent at all. In fact, research shows they are more likely to be victims of violence rather than perpetrators. Learning this helped me realize how harmful these stereotypes can be, and it made me more aware of the importance of reducing stigma and showing empathy toward people who struggle with mental health issues.

Media Representations of Psychology

When I think about how psychology is shown in the media, I realize it is often exaggerated or simplified.

- In movies and TV shows, psychologists are usually shown as therapists who solve someone's problems in just one dramatic session. This gave me the impression that therapy was quick and easy, but I now understand that real therapy takes time, effort, and collaboration.
- Hypnosis is another example. I used to see it portrayed as a kind of mind control trick where people could be forced to do things against their will. After learning in class, I know hypnosis is actually a therapeutic technique with specific uses, like helping with pain or breaking habits, and it is nothing like the way it is shown in films.

- Mental illness is often misrepresented too. Many movies show people with conditions like schizophrenia or bipolar disorder as dangerous or unstable. This reinforced stereotypes I had heard before. In reality, most people with mental illness are not violent, and these portrayals only add to stigma.
- On social media, I often come across “psychology hacks” or motivational posts that make psychology look like a set of quick tricks to be more successful or happy. Now I realize these are oversimplifications, and real psychology is based on research and evidence, not catchy slogans.

Looking back, I can see how these portrayals shaped my early beliefs about psychology. They made the field seem either magical or overly simple, when in truth it is a complex and scientific discipline.

Reflection

Before this course, I thought psychology was mostly about mind reading, therapy, or just common sense, and those ideas came from movies, TV shows, and what people around me said. After learning in class, I now see psychology as a proper science that studies behaviour and mental processes through research and evidence. This change has made me more thoughtful and critical. I question stereotypes, I understand that mental illness is often misunderstood, and I appreciate that intelligence can grow in different ways. Going forward, I know this new perspective will help me communicate more responsibly, think more analytically, and make decisions with greater empathy and respect for others.

My thoughts have changed in a few clear ways:

- I don't just accept things as “common sense” anymore. I try to question them.
- I understand that research and critical thinking are important to know why people act the way they do.
- I look at movies and social media more carefully and can tell when psychology is shown in an exaggerated way.

This new learning will guide me in the future:

- I will talk about mental health more responsibly and avoid spreading myths.
- I will make decisions with more awareness of psychological ideas, like knowing how biases affect judgment.
- I will treat people with empathy, remembering that behaviour is shaped by many factors we may not see.

Overall, psychology is no longer just a set of stereotypes for me. It has become a science that helps me understand people in a deeper and more meaningful way. This new perspective will stay me nad guide how I learn, how I communicate, and how I interact with others in everyday life.

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